

THE FRIENDS WITH FOUR KEYS • THREE FOUNDATIONS • RULED 2026-09-11

After six adversary rounds on the trusting-forgery premise (v0.3 to v0.8), every round converging on the same joints, Stephen asked whether the process was getting anywhere or churning. The diagnosis: the device (a forged trust rather than a forged fear) was never broken; the churn came from the money being asked to do opposite jobs, and from attacking a partial document that omitted canon. These three rulings settle the joints. They are inputs to spine v2.0, which is the next artifact and the next thing to be attacked. Spine v2.0.7 was ruled the episode's spine on 2026-09-14; premise v8.1 is superseded; these three rulings (foundation 2 as restated on 2026-09-13) bind it.

Foundation 1. The van money: the occasion, never the motive

The van money is modest (a second-hand van and a first stock eight years ago; a sum a working signwriter could repay in a good year and a woman paying a lawyer would still want back), lent in cash on no paper by Violet's choice against Margo's advice, and unenforceable by anyone, including her estate. All four know the loan; only Brad and Margo know she was calling it in this autumn for the hearing; the café heard her say she was calling in what she was owed, no name.

Consequences. The calling-in is why Brad is in her house on the last Monday of the month with the book coming down the stairs; it is why there is a Day 0 and not a Day 12; it is not why she dies. Liam's "where did you find it?" is answered by a good year and the yard's own tender work. When the estate's accountant asks, Brad says orally that Vi helped him out years ago and it was settled between them, nothing in writing either way; the sister's solicitor advises there is nothing to claim, a documented write-off. Margo says everything she knows about the money to the estate, and nothing about a letter. Her arrival is a fact she gets from the estate and did not hold on Day 14: the solicitor's account for the hearing was unpaid when Violet died, so the money the letter says was repaid in the autumn never went where it was for. The kind line in the forgery is neutral, no date, no "out of the blue": Brad paid me back the van money this autumn, every penny; I put it here because it is the one thing this year that went right. Nothing in it is false to Margo's knowledge on the night. The money can never again be the reason anyone does anything except visit.

Foundation 2. Why Violet has to die: the mark

The panel is Brad's alphabet, derived from hers and better, signed with the mark he will sign under for the rest of his life; a signwriter is what he will be wherever he goes, and that hand is his fingerprint. It was in her roof because her bench on Tuesday nights was the only place he could make it. She carried it round the trade asking whose hand, then, in front of him on Day -19, locked it in a brick store behind a padlock whose only keys went to a solicitor to be posted at her death.

A faked death does not help him: the panel stays in the store under her name, she keeps asking, and one day four people open a door with his mark inside and her account of where she found it. A living Violet is not his mourner; she is a locked box with his name in it and a woman still looking for the hand. Her death is the only key to that door, and it hands him the letter as well. The debt is why he is in her house that Monday. The grief

is the shape his own death will wear. The reason is the mark. He does not care whether she has cleared him; he cares what is behind the door.

Restated by Stephen, 2026-09-13 (after Fable round 4 on spine v2.0.5). The reason is not the mark, which is two initials with no face and dangerous to nobody but her. The reason is Violet herself: alive, she knows a hidden self was built at her bench for ten months, whether he claims the panel or not; she forgets nobody and has the trade's ear; she is the one person who would never believe his drowning and would ask the trade, the yard and the box until she found where he went. Claiming the panel confirms the hidden self to that mind; denying it leaves his work locked in a box she keeps asking about. Either way she has to be dead on the day he is. Her death also opens the store and hands him her letter. Spine v2.0.6 carries this wording.

Foundation 3. What Violet does when it happens again: she takes the key in

After the tin she changes the lock (Day -37), has one new spare cut, puts it in the second pot by the yard door and tells the four on the slip, because the spare is for them. About Day -30 her mother is facing the door again: Brad, with the new spare, deliberately, a probe to see whether she would tell the four. She does not. She takes the key in that morning, onto her own ring, and tells nobody. Her book: I've taken the key in. If it stops, it was one of them or it was me. I would rather not know which.

She does not watch. A phone on the shelf would tell her which, and the one thing she can bear less than being wrong about her own mind is being right about a friend; her whole design is not knowing while she lives and their knowing after. Withdrawing the key accuses nobody and answers nothing, which is the amount of answer she wants.

Consequences. Day -9 Brad finds the pot empty, does not enter, and knows she has closed the house and told nobody, which is the acceleration; the plan is made at the store door on Day -19 and completed on Day 0 with the book in his hands, which he knows she keeps upstairs because he has watched her fetch it. Day 1: Liam cannot let himself in, sees her through the kitchen window, breaks a pane; the police note forced entry by the friend who found her. Day 15: the room's pool-closer is three sentences of hers in order: she changed her lock and told us four; it happened again; she took the key in and said nothing, and it stopped.

What follows

Not another delta. Spine v2.0: the full document, all parts, every canon fact in it, built the way v1.4 was, with these three foundations and the surviving rulings of the six rounds (the ashes; intestacy; the sister with her own people; Margo outside the estate; the store's construction and rent; no fifth key; keys cut, used and lodged in one morning; the panel shown at the store door; one glass; Brad never in her house after Day 0; the box number as chapter 7, a suspect turn; the kind line; the instruction with her reason; Ruby's doubt answered by Liam; Day 82 via Ruby). Then two adversaries on v2.0.